ANTI-MUSIC

PINK SPIDER

Console preamp → FET limiter → A/D → analog harmonics.

USER MANUAL



From Canada with love

BETA · VST3 · AU · MAC & WINDOWS

WELCOME

Thanks for testing Pink Spider

Pink Spider is the channel you put first on every track: a console preamp, a tube stage, two limiters and a converter, then four analog colours. Think of it as plugging each track into a great console before it hits your DAW.

In this manual

1 Install 3

2 Quick start 5

3 A tour of the window 6

4 Low cut & phase 7

5 Display & tilt EQ 8

6 The Spider section 9

7 FET LIMIT 10

8 Harmonic processing 11

9 Meter & lights 12

10 Sounds to try 13

11 Troubleshooting & uninstall 14

12 Report a bug 15

What you get

COMPUTER	FORMATS
Mac	VST3 and Audio Unit macOS 11 or newer, Apple Silicon or Intel
Windows	VST3 Windows 10 or 11, 64-bit

Works in Logic Pro, GarageBand, Ableton Live, Cubase, Reaper, Studio One, Bitwig, FL Studio and other VST3 / AU hosts. The Pro Tools (AAX) version comes later.

This is a beta

Pink Spider is close to finished, but not quite. Things may break or change between versions. **Please tell us about anything odd**, however small: see Report a bug.

DOWNLOAD

Installers and updates are always at github.com/BigDumbRobot/Pink-Spider-Beta

CHAPTER 1

Install

Download the installer for your computer from the Releases page, then follow the steps below. It takes about a minute.

On a Mac

File: `Pink-Spider-<version>-macOS.pkg`

1. **Quit your DAW.**
2. **Double-click the installer.**
3. If macOS says it *can't be opened* or *Apple could not verify* it, click **Done**. Then open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**, scroll down to the message about the Pink Spider installer, and click **Open Anyway**. Enter your password and click **Open**.
4. **Follow the installer.** It installs both the VST3 and the Audio Unit. Click **Customize** if you only want one.
5. **Open your DAW** and look for **Pink Spider** under **Anti-Music**.

> **WHY THE WARNING?**
> Beta installers aren't signed by Apple yet, so macOS asks you to confirm. That's expected, and it only happens the first time. On macOS 12 and earlier, you can instead **right-click** the installer and choose **Open**.

The plugins go to `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/Pink Spider.vst3` and `/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/Pink Spider.component`.

On Windows

File: `Pink-Spider-<version>-Windows-Setup.exe`

1. **Quit your DAW.**
2. **Double-click the installer.**
3. If you see **"Windows protected your PC"**, click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.
4. Click **Yes** to allow changes, accept the beta licence, then click **Install**.
5. **Open your DAW** and rescan plugins if it doesn't do it automatically. Pink Spider is listed under **Anti-Music**.

> **WHY THE WARNING?**
> The beta installer isn't signed yet, so Windows SmartScreen asks before running it. That's expected.

The plugin goes to `C:\Program Files\Common Files\VST3\Pink Spider.vst3`, the standard folder every Windows DAW checks.

Updating to a newer beta

Just run the new installer. It replaces the old version, and your sessions keep their Pink Spider settings.

Rescanning in your DAW

DAW	WHAT TO DO
Ableton Live	Settings → Plug-Ins → turn on **Use VST3 Plug-In System Folders**, then **Rescan**.
Logic Pro / GarageBand	Restart. Logic checks new Audio Units on launch.
Reaper	Preferences → Plug-ins → VST → **Re-scan**.
FL Studio	Options → Manage plugins → **Find plugins**.
Cubase, Studio One, Bitwig	Restart. They scan on launch.

CHAPTER 2

2 Quick start

Sound in thirty seconds.

1. **Put Pink Spider on a track, first in the chain.** When it opens, it does *nothing* to your sound: everything starts off or neutral.
2. **Add colour.** Turn **TRIODE** or **TAPE** up to about **4**.
3. **Thicken it.** Light **FATTER** for a warmer, fuller middle.
4. **Drive the preamp.** Click **GAIN** to **More**, then pull **LEVEL** down until it's as loud as before.
5. **Control it.** Light **FET LIMIT** for 1176-style attitude.

> **HEAR WHAT IT'S DOING**
> Click the round lens next to **SPIDER** or **HARMONIC PROCESSING** to switch that whole section off and on.

How the sound flows

THE SPIDER SECTION



HARMONIC PROCESSING



- **LEVEL comes before the limiters and the A/D.** It decides how hard you hit FET LIMIT, BRICK WALL and the converter. Turning LEVEL up means more limiting, not only more volume.
- The four harmonic colours come **after** the converter, like an outboard box on the insert.
- The **tilt EQ** runs last. Light **PRE** to put it first instead.

CHAPTER 3

3 A tour of the window

Everything is on one screen.



A **Top bar**
Your track name on console tape.

B **Low cut & phase**
Clean up the lows and line up your mics. Chapter 4.

C **Spectrum display**
See your sound, and tilt its tone. Chapter 5.

D **Spider section**
Preamp, level, FATTER and FET LIMIT. Chapters 6 and 7.

E **Harmonic processing**
Iron, triode, pentode and tape. Chapter 8.

F **A/D meter & lights**
Converter level, CLIP, OVER and the BRICK WALL switch. Chapter 9.

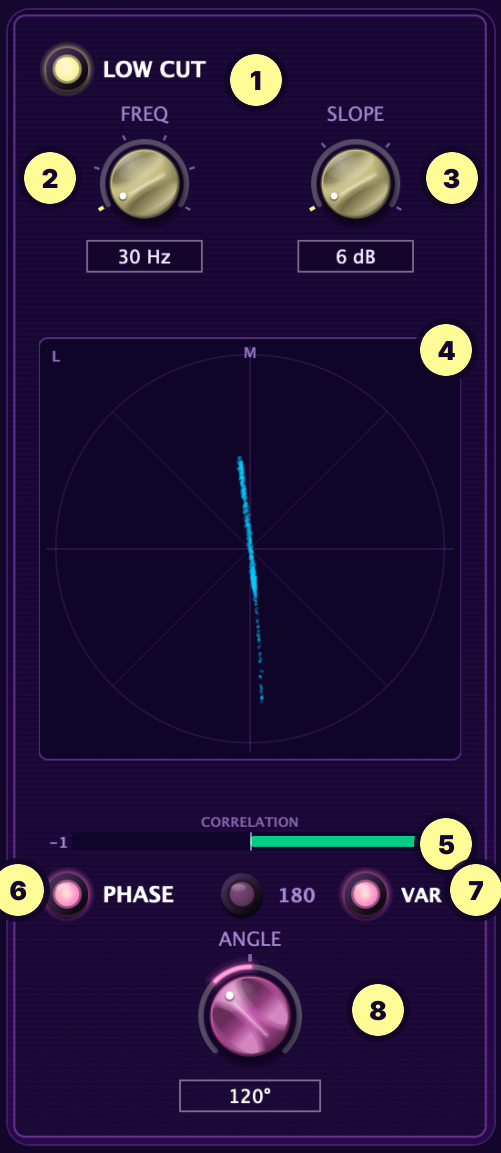
Handy everywhere

- **Drag** a knob up or down to turn it, or **click its value box** to type a value. **Double-click** a knob to reset it.
- A **lit lens** means on. The lens next to a section's title switches the whole section.
- Every copy keeps **its own settings**, and latency is only a few samples, so use one on every track and record through it.

CHAPTER 4

Low cut & phase

Clean up the bottom end, and make two mics on one source work together.



1. **LOW CUT**
   Switches the low cut in or out. It starts out.
2. **FREQ**
   Where it cuts: 30, 50, 80, 100, 160 or 300 Hz.
3. **SLOPE**
   How steeply: 6, 12, 18 or 24 dB per octave. Bigger numbers cut harder.
4. **Phase scope**
   Your stereo image. A **vertical line** is mono. **Spread sideways** is wide. **Lying flat** means out of phase: hollow, and it can vanish in mono.
5. **CORRELATION**
   +1 is mono and safe, around **0** is very wide, **left of centre** is out of phase.
6. **PHASE**
   Switches the phase section in or out.
7. **180 / VAR**
   180 flips the waveform upside down. **VAR** rotates the phase by the ANGLE knob. Picking either switches PHASE on.
8. **ANGLE**
   0° to 360°, in VAR only. It clicks into place at 180°.

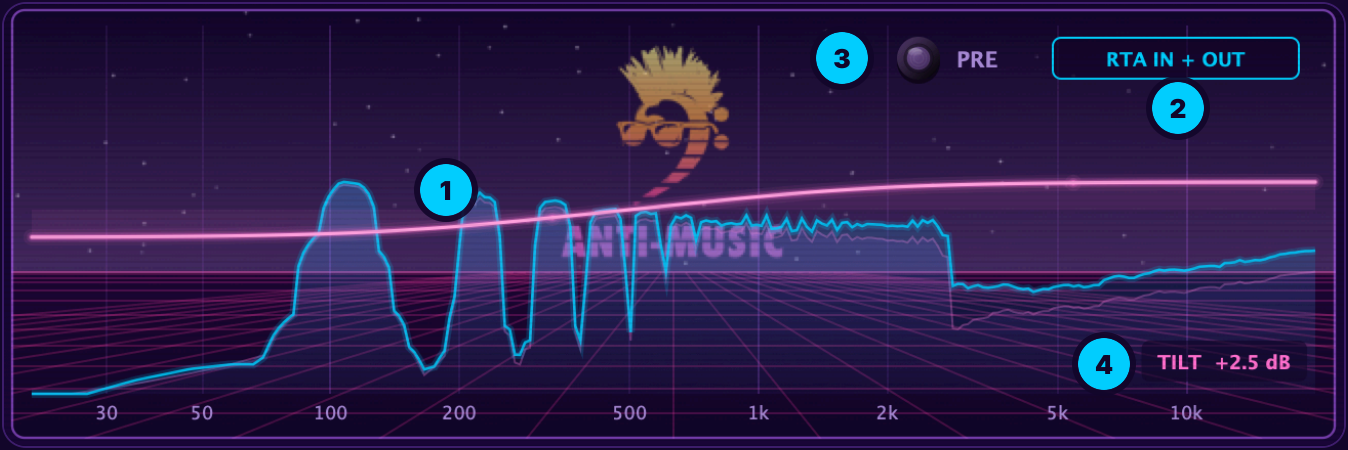
TRY THIS

Low cut: vocals 80–100 Hz at 12 dB, guitars 80 Hz, overheads 160 Hz. Two mics on one source: try **180**, or pick **VAR** and sweep **ANGLE** until the low end sounds fullest.

CHAPTER 5

5 Display & tilt EQ

See the frequencies in your sound, and tilt the whole tone brighter or darker with one gesture.



1. **Spectrum**
   Lowest bass on the left, highest treble on the right. Faint purple is your sound **before** Pink Spider, bright blue is **after**.

2. **RTA label**
   Click it to switch between **IN + OUT**, **IN**, **OUT** and **OFF**.

3. **PRE**
   Moves the tilt EQ to the **start** of the chain, so it changes what goes into the preamp and harmonics.

4. **Tilt amount**
   Shows while the tilt isn't flat, with the curve drawn over the spectrum.

Using the tilt EQ

The tilt EQ works like a seesaw around 500 Hz: when the treble goes up, the bass goes down, and the other way round. Up to ±6 dB at each end.

DO THIS	RESULT
Hold `Shift` and drag up on the spectrum	**Brighter**: more treble, less bass
Hold `Shift` and drag down	**Darker**: more bass, less treble
Right-click the spectrum → Reset Tilt	Back to flat. It also clicks into place at flat as you drag.

TRY THIS

A slightly **darker** tilt with **PRE** lit makes the preamp and harmonics distort more smoothly, with less fizz.

CHAPTER 6

The Spider section

The console channel: a preamp, a level control and a tube stage, feeding the limiters and the converter.



1 SPIDER
Switches the whole section in or out. While it's out, the panel greys over; low cut, phase and harmonics keep working.

2 GAIN
The console preamp. Five clicks, from **6** to **66**. Starts at **Unity**.

3 LEVEL
The channel output, −60 to +12 dB. Sets how hard the limiters and the A/D are hit.

4 FATTER
A tube stage: thicker and warmer, mostly 2nd harmonic. Quiet parts stay clean, loud parts get fatter.

5 FET LIMIT
An 1176-style limiter in front of the converter. Chapter 7.

GAIN

POSITION	6	LESS	UNITY	MORE	66
Into the preamp	−30 dB	−15 dB	**no change**	+15 dB	+30 dB

> **GAIN UP, LEVEL DOWN**
> More GAIN drives the preamp, FATTER, the limiters and the converter harder. Turn **LEVEL** down by about the same amount so you're comparing tone, not loudness. Switching GAIN never clicks or jumps.

CHAPTER 7

7 FET LIMIT

A limiter modelled on the classic 1176 "blue stripe", set up the way many engineers love it, and placed right in front of the converter.

SETTING	VALUE	WHAT YOU HEAR
Ratio	20:1, always	Full limiting. It holds the level firmly.
Attack	Slowest (about 800 µs)	The **front of each hit punches through** before it clamps.
Release	Fastest (50 ms)	Lively and aggressive. It stretches a little, to about 120 ms, when it's limiting hard and long.
Where it starts	About −3 dBFS	Keeps the converter from going over.

How to use it

1. Light **FET LIMIT**.
2. Turn **LEVEL** up. The more you push, the harder it grabs.
3. For more attitude, click **GAIN** to **More** as well.
4. Switch it off and on to compare at the same loudness.

What it does to the sound

- Like the real one, it is a **feedback** design: it listens to its own output, so the first moment of a peak gets through before it clamps.
- As it limits harder, the FET adds a little **2nd harmonic**, the warm edge the 1176 is known for.
- The fast release rides low notes slightly, which adds growl on bass and drums.

GREAT ON

Vocals, bass, room mics and drum busses.

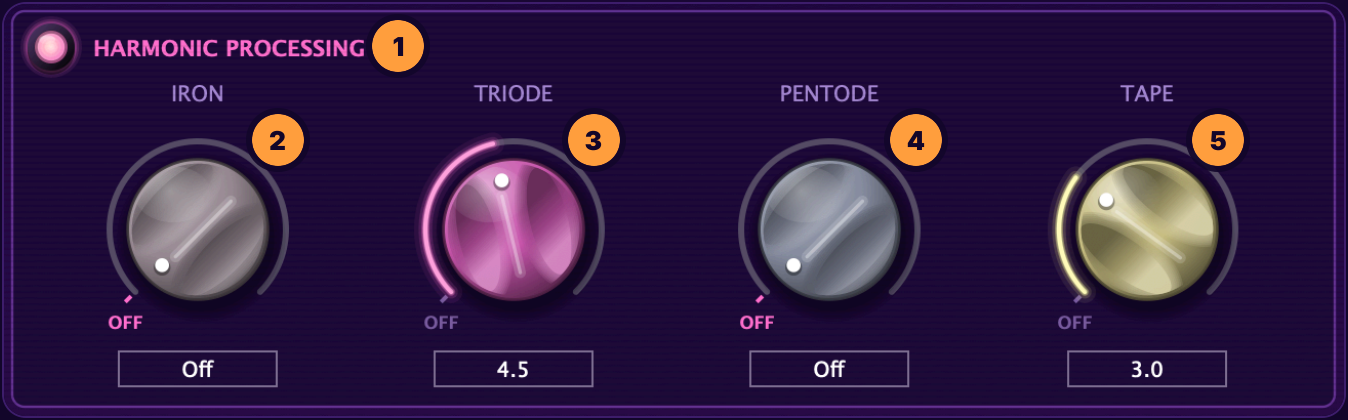
FET LIMIT OR BRICK WALL?

FET LIMIT is the sound: colour and squash. **BRICK WALL** is the safety net: it just catches peaks. You can use both. BRICK WALL is switched from the light under the meter: see Chapter 9.

CHAPTER 8

8 Harmonic processing

Four analog colours after the converter, in this order: iron, triode, pentode, tape. Use one, or stack them.



1. **HARMONIC PROCESSING**
   Switches all four in or out together.

2. **IRON**
   An input transformer: **thicker, tighter lows** while the highs stay open. For kick, bass, anything that needs weight.

3. **TRIODE**
   Warm, round and fat (even harmonics). For vocals, acoustic guitar, anything thin.

4. **PENTODE**
   Brighter, more detail, a bit of squash (odd harmonics). For vocals that need to cut, snare, guitars.

5. **TAPE**
   Tape saturation: the highs soften first, with a low-end bump. For drums, busses, taming harsh sources.

How far to turn them

KNOB	OFF	1 TO 3	4 TO 6	7 TO 10
Sounds	Fully left, clicks in	Subtle: you feel it	**Clearly coloured**	Heavy, into distortion

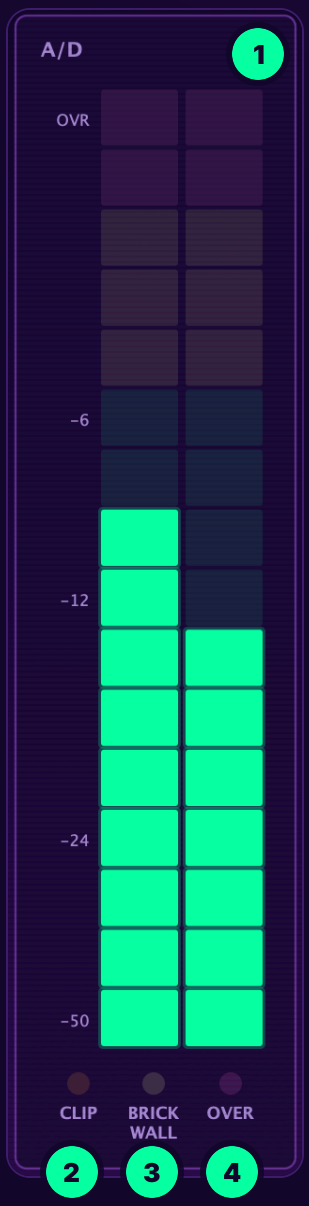
NO OVERS

These four never cause an over. Pushing them makes the sound denser and louder, but peaks stay below full scale.

CHAPTER 9

9 Meter & lights

The level hitting the converter, and three lights that tell you when to back off.



1 · The A/D meter

Shows the peak level going into the converter, in dBFS, for each channel. **Green** is healthy. **Yellow** is getting hot. The top segment, **OVR**, means a digital over.

The lights

2 · CLIP

The preamp is being pushed past its headroom. Click **GAIN** down a step.

3 · BRICK WALL

This light is also a switch. Click it to turn the brick-wall peak limiter on or off.

off · on · limiting right now

4 · OVER

The signal went over full scale at the converter. Turn **LEVEL** down, or light **FET LIMIT** or **BRICK WALL**.

> **BRICK WALL**
> A fast peak limiter that catches peaks just below full scale, linked across both channels so the stereo image doesn't shift. Use it as a safety net when tracking hot.

CHAPTER 10

10 Sounds to try

Starting points. Begin from the defaults (double-click knobs to reset), set these, then adjust to taste.

Lead vocal

Present, controlled, warm

- LOW CUT 80 Hz / 12 dB
- GAIN More
- LEVEL down to match
- FET LIMIT on
- TRIODE 3
- PENTODE 2

Bass

Weight and growl that sits

- GAIN More
- FATTER on
- IRON 4
- TAPE 3
- FET LIMIT on

Kick

Tight low end, safe peaks

- IRON 5
- TRIODE 3
- BRICK WALL on

Snare

Crack and body

- PENTODE 4
- TAPE 3
- Bottom mic 180

Acoustic guitar

Full without the boom

- LOW CUT 100 Hz
- TRIODE 3
- TILT a little brighter

Electric guitar

Bite and glue

- LOW CUT 80 Hz
- PENTODE 3
- TAPE 2

Smashed room

Drum room mics, parallel crush

- GAIN More
- FET LIMIT on
- LEVEL up until it pumps
- TAPE 4

Mix bus

Gentle glue and colour

- GAIN Unity
- IRON 2
- TAPE 2 to 3
- TILT to taste

CHAPTER 11

Troubleshooting

Most problems have a quick fix.

PROBLEM	FIX
Pink Spider doesn't show up in my DAW	Restart the DAW and rescan plugins (see Install). In Logic: **Logic Pro → Settings → Plug-in Manager**, select Pink Spider, **Reset & Rescan Selection**.
The Mac says the installer can't be opened, or is damaged	Use **Open Anyway** in **System Settings → Privacy & Security**. If it still refuses, run this in Terminal, then open the installer again: `xattr -d com.apple.quarantine ~/Downloads/Pink-Spider-*-macOS.pkg`
It's louder or quieter than without it	Set **GAIN** to **Unity** and **LEVEL** to **0 dB**. With FATTER, both limiters and the four harmonic knobs off, Pink Spider doesn't change your sound.
It sounds distorted	Watch the **CLIP** and **OVER** lights. Click GAIN down a step, lower LEVEL, or turn the harmonic knobs down.
The BRICK WALL light is red all the time	It's limiting constantly. Turn **LEVEL** down until it only flashes red on peaks.
Where's the Pro Tools version?	Not in this beta. The AAX version needs to be signed first. It's coming.

Uninstall

Mac

In Finder, choose **Go → Go to Folder...** and delete:

`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/VST3/Pink Spider.vst3`

`/Library/Audio/Plug-Ins/Components/Pink Spider.component`

Windows

Open **Settings → Apps → Installed apps**, find **Pink Spider (Anti-Music) beta**, and click **Uninstall**.

CHAPTER 12

12 Report a bug

Thank you for testing. Please report everything, even small things. That's what the beta is for.

Open an issue at

github.com/BigDumbRobot/Pink-Spider-Beta/issues

Pick **Bug report** or **Feedback or idea**. A free GitHub account is needed.

For bugs, please include

- Your computer (Mac or Windows) and its OS version
- Your DAW and its version
- The Pink Spider version (it's in the installer's file name)
- What you did, what you expected, and what happened
- A screenshot or short recording, if you can
- If your DAW crashed, its crash report, if it made one



Now go make it sound expensive.

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